

### music festival

## Mystical Revival

**TALLAPAKA, ANDHRA PRADESH**

His 32,000 *sankeertanas*—devotional songs—in praise of Lord Venkateswara have spawned a whole genre of bhakti music. The Telugu saint-composer Annamacharya was the earliest widely revered musician of south India. In an extraordinary tribute to mark his 600th birth anniversary, as an extension of the Annamacharya Project started by the Tirumala Tirupati Devasthanams (TTD) in 1978, his devotional music is being promoted and Tallapaka—his birthplace, 90 km from the temple-town of Tirupati near Rajampet in Cuddapah—is being developed.

In May, Tallapaka was the venue for a four-day festival—the first concerted initiative to make the composer's *kritis* popular. Classical musicians, writers and poets rendered the *sankeertanas*, while dancers presented ballets. Braving the heat, 600 artistes, led by noted vocalists P.B. Srinivas and Shobha Raju, gave evocative performances, leaving

the 30,000-strong audience spellbound.

Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister Y.S. Rajasekhara Reddy unveiled a 108-foot-tall statue of Annamacharya in the gaily-decorated village. Violinist Kunnakudi Vaidyanathan, dancers Padma Subrahmanyam and Vempati Chinna Satyam, musicians Nedunuri Krishnamurthy and Garimella Balakrishna Prasad, actor-dancers Shobhana and Manju Bhargavi, mridangam exponent Yella Venkateswara Rao, singers Dwaram Lakshmi, Jyothirmayee Chowdary and the Hyderabad sisters were among those who participated in the celebrations.

"We hope to offer a fitting tribute to the saint by developing Tallapaka as a centre for devotional music and also as a tourist destination in the style of Stratford-upon-Avon, the birthplace of William Shakespeare," says TTD Chairman B. Karunakar Reddy. With the village becoming hallowed destination, the stage is set for Annamacharya's spiritual legacy to be carried forward.

by Amarnath K. Menon

**SPIRIT OF DEVOTION: Actor-dancer Shobhana performs**

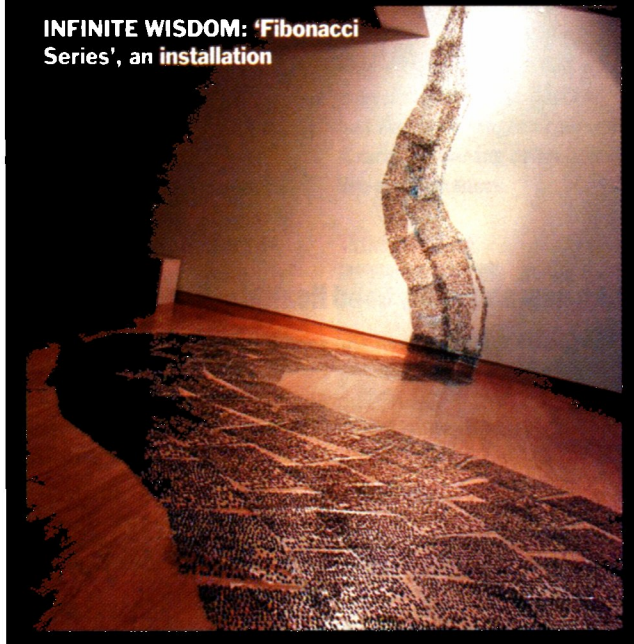


art

## The Human Condition

**MUMBAI** It is a profound creative journey that explores the purpose of life. A three-part show by Enith Perez, Srinivas Mangipudi and Priyasri Patodia, it comprises an eight-minute video, a series of 20 photographs and a large installation called the Fibonacci Series. Says curator-artist Patodia, "Many in body, one in mind—for me, this is a venture in experimental art. It is a realisation that all human beings are governed by the same desire for comfort, happiness and satisfaction." The video relives the story of a flute which, after falling from a height, laments its death before it could perform. The installation extends this theme, with scores of human backs stretched out like ants to depict their relative insignificance on the larger canvas of the world. At Priyasri Art Gallery, Worli, till June 18. by Swati Mathur

**INFINITE WISDOM: 'Fibonacci Series', an installation**



music

## Joy of Learning

**KOLKATA** Promoting the *guru-shishya* tradition, santoor maestro Tarun Bhattacharya has set up an ashram outside the city. "The idea is to teach music to the talented yet economically handicapped," says Bhattacharya, who also organises concerts through the year. So if you want to take a break and enjoy



**STRING KING: Bhatt**  
Pandit Vishwamohan Bhatt's mohan veena, Sushmita Banerjee's Kathak and Rajendra Sijuar's vocal rendering amidst mango trees, you know where to head. On June 23.